Nomination Event Formats - Running List of Ideas

Think of this as a **menu of options**, not a strict playbook.

Pick what fits your community's size, maturity, and venue constraints, and feel free to remix.

A few practical notes before you choose:

- If you expect lots of interest, you can ask people to submit their Clay tables/workspace links ahead of time.
- You can shortlist ~3–4 finalists for live builds to keep the event tight and high-quality.
- You can still keep it fair by using the same prompt + same timing + same rubric for the finalists.
- If you're shortlisting, be transparent: share what you're looking for (clarity, execution, coachability).

Reminder: These are ONLY ideas. If you try something new that works, share it, we'll keep evolving this list and turn the best ones into a proper playbook over time.

▼ Option 1: Mini Clay Cup

A fast-paced, structured version that feels closest to the real thing.

How it works

Everyone gets the same prompt and a short window to build. You watch how they think, not just what they ship.

- Each participant gets **10–15 minutes** to build live
- The prompt is **identical for everyone**
- Judging is done by **you + 1-2 trusted community members**

Works best when

- You have a medium–large club with multiple strong candidates
- You want a process that feels fair, structured, and easy to explain

Nice add-on

Ask people to submit their tables ahead of time, shortlist **3–4 finalists**, and run live builds only with them on event day. This keeps energy high and timelines tight.

Option 2: Live Build + Q&A

Less “competition vibe,” more “watch how people think.” Great for newer communities.

How it works

- Participants build live and **talk through their approach**
- Audience asks **clarifying questions** (keep these short)
- Optimize for **reasoning and decision-making**, not polish

Works best when

- Your community is newer to Clay Cup or live competitions
- You want the room to learn together, not just judge

Host tip

- You can still time-box builds so the night doesn’t run long.

Option 3: Coach-Led Challenge

Perfect if you don’t have time for lots of live builds, or your venue setup is limited.

How it works

- Share a short prompt ahead of time (take-home)
- Ask candidates to submit their table(s) before the event
- Shortlist finalists
- Finalists present live and coach/judges give **structured feedback**

Works best when

- You have limited event time or bandwidth
- You want to reduce event-day chaos but still keep a merit-based process

▼ Option 4: Virtual Rounds (Fully Online or Hybrid)

Virtual rounds are totally valid, especially for geographically spread communities or when IRL logistics are heavy.

Think of these as **signal-finding rounds**, not full production events.

Idea A: Async Submission → Live Virtual Finals

- Share a prompt + submission deadline
- Ask candidates to submit their Clay table / loom / short write-up
- Shortlist **3-4 finalists**
- Run a **live Zoom round** where finalists walk through their build (5-10 min each)

Works best when

- Your community is spread across cities or time zones
- You want to lower the barrier to participation

Idea B: Timed Virtual Build (Zoom)

- All participants join a Zoom room
- Share the prompt live
- Give everyone **20-30 minutes** to build
- Select a few participants to present live

Host tip

- Cameras on are mandatory
- Ask participants to think out loud when presenting

Idea C: Small-Group Virtual Rooms

- Break participants into **3 - 5 person breakout rooms**
- Each room has the same prompt
- One facilitator per room (host / trusted community member)
- Facilitators nominate 1 standout participant per room